第1セット / The Return of Urban Wildlife

Script

In recent years, many cities around the world have experienced an unexpected increase in wildlife populations. Animals such as foxes, deer, and various species of birds are becoming more common in urban environments.

One reason for this trend is the expansion of green spaces. City governments have been creating parks, planting trees, and restoring rivers to improve residents' quality of life. These efforts have unintentionally provided suitable habitats for wild animals.

However, the growing presence of wildlife has also created challenges. In some neighborhoods, animals have damaged gardens, caused traffic accidents, and spread diseases. As a result, local authorities must find ways to protect both wildlife and residents.

Some cities have introduced educational programs that teach people how to avoid attracting wild animals. For example, residents are encouraged to secure their garbage and avoid feeding animals.

Experts believe that urban wildlife will continue to increase as cities become greener. They emphasize that successful coexistence will require careful planning and cooperation between governments and local communities.

Q1. What has contributed to the increase in wildlife in cities?

Q2. According to experts, what will help cities and wildlife coexist?

Q1. 選択肢

(1) New laws requiring residents to keep wild animals.
(2) Green-space projects that unintentionally created habitats.
(3) A decline in the number of parks and rivers.
(4) Programs encouraging people to feed wild animals.

Q2. 選択肢

(1) Moving all wild animals to rural areas.
(2) Stopping all new park construction.
(3) Careful planning and cooperation with local communities.
(4) Allowing wildlife to enter residential homes.

第2セット / Repair Cafés and a Culture of Reuse

Script

In many towns, appliances that stop working are quickly replaced, even when the damage is minor. To challenge this habit, residents have started repair cafés, where volunteers help people fix household items for free. Visitors bring broken lamps, small radios, or clothing and work alongside experienced hobbyists.

The gatherings offer practical advantages. A repaired object stays out of a landfill, and owners learn how it works, making them more confident about fixing it again. Repair cafés also give neighbors a reason to meet. Older participants may share skills they learned, while younger visitors contribute digital knowledge.

Still, organizers say these events cannot solve every problem. Some products are difficult to open, and replacement parts may be unavailable. Volunteers also need to avoid giving the impression that a quick repair is always safe. For this reason, many cafés refuse to handle appliances that could cause electric shocks or fires.

Local governments have begun supporting the events by lending rooms and publicizing their schedules. Organizers hope that the cafés will encourage manufacturers to make products easier to repair. They see each gathering as a small step toward a culture that values maintenance as much as buying something new.

Q1. What is one benefit of repair cafés mentioned in the passage?

Q2. Why do many repair cafés refuse to handle certain appliances?

Q1. 選択肢

(1) They teach visitors how to manufacture new appliances.
(2) They help reduce waste while giving owners repair skills.
(3) They guarantee that every household product can be fixed.
(4) They provide replacement parts for all older devices.

Q2. 選択肢

(1) The owners usually do not want to learn about them.
(2) The devices are too new to be examined by volunteers.
(3) A repair could create risks such as electric shock or fire.
(4) Local governments have prohibited all electrical repairs.

第3セット / When Migratory Birds Arrive Earlier

Script

For decades, biologists assumed that certain migratory birds began their spring journeys mainly in response to warmer weather. Researchers studying birds have found that some species are arriving earlier than they did in the past. Rising temperatures may explain the change, but the full picture is complicated.

Many birds use several signals to decide when to migrate. Day length changes little, while temperature and food supplies can change quickly. Birds that leave before insects become plentiful may struggle to feed their young. Those that wait too long, however, could miss the best nesting sites.

Researchers compared decades of arrival records with local temperature data. They found that some birds adjusted their timing, while others showed little change. This difference may be connected to how each species senses environmental signals and how far it travels. Long-distance migrants may be less able to respond to conditions near their destination because they spend much of the winter elsewhere.

Scientists say these findings make predictions difficult. Even if average temperatures rise, not every species will benefit equally. Protecting a variety of habitats along migration routes could help birds cope with changing conditions. More research is needed to understand which species are most at risk.

Q1. What did researchers discover about the timing of bird migration?

Q2. Why might long-distance migrants respond less to conditions near their destination?

Q1. 選択肢

(1) All species now begin their journeys at the same time.
(2) Most birds wait until insects have disappeared.
(3) Temperature has no effect on when birds travel.
(4) Some species changed their timing, while others changed little.

Q2. 選択肢

(1) They avoid traveling during the winter.
(2) They spend much of the winter somewhere else.
(3) They always arrive after nesting sites have closed.
(4) They cannot detect changes in day length anywhere.

第4セット / Seed Banks for a Changing Climate

Script

Unpredictable weather forces some farmers to choose between familiar crops and varieties better suited to heat and drought. A seed bank stores seeds from many plant varieties for future use.

Seed banks are not merely vaults. Staff and farmers often grow samples to ensure germination and record each variety's origin. Local crops may carry traits that help plants survive salty soil, resist disease, or produce food with little water. These could prove valuable as climate changes.

Some collections also lend seeds to farmers who test them in local fields. Reports from these trials help scientists learn whether a promising trait remains useful under everyday growing conditions.

However, preserving seeds requires more than keeping them cold and dry. Some varieties need regular replanting because their seeds do not remain healthy for long. Farming knowledge can also disappear if experienced growers are excluded. Many programs therefore work directly with farming communities instead of collecting seeds alone.

Researchers compare varieties and identify traits that might strengthen future crops. Rather than replacing modern agriculture, seed banks can offer farmers options when familiar crops fail. Their success depends on long-term funding and cooperation between scientists and communities that maintain this knowledge.

Q1. Why could local crop varieties be valuable in the future?

Q2. Why do many seed programs work directly with farming communities?

Q1. 選択肢

(1) They may have traits that help crops handle difficult conditions.
(2) They can grow without farmers or scientific support.
(3) They always produce more food than modern crops.
(4) They remove the need to store seeds in collections.

Q2. 選択肢

(1) To replace scientists with traditional farmers.
(2) To avoid testing seeds in actual fields.
(3) To prevent farmers from growing familiar crops.
(4) To preserve practical knowledge as well as seeds.

第5セット / Finding Quiet in a Busy City

Script

City planners are studying how sound affects public spaces. Busy squares may be lively and convenient, but traffic and construction can make it hard to rest or talk. Some neighborhoods are testing quiet areas where visitors can take a break without leaving the city.

These places are not always silent. Designers use trees, low walls, or building shapes to reduce traffic noise. They also consider pleasant sounds, such as birdsong or water. Researchers measure sound levels and ask residents how they experience a space. A spot that seems quiet may still feel uncomfortable if people feel unsafe.

Urban land is limited, so creating quiet areas can be difficult. Businesses may worry that barriers make streets less welcoming, and maintenance costs can be high. Some planners begin with small changes, such as closing one street to traffic on weekends or adding benches behind trees.

The aim is not to remove all city sounds. Planners want to give residents choices about where to gather, work, or recover from a busy day. Local feedback helps them decide which changes are most useful for different people.

Q1. Why do researchers ask residents about their experience of a space?

Q2. What is the main aim of creating quiet areas in cities?

Q1. 選択肢

(1) To learn which trees grow fastest in the city.
(2) To determine whether businesses support weekend events.
(3) Because measured sound levels do not show how safe or comfortable a place feels.
(4) Because they plan to remove every source of city noise.

Q2. 選択肢

(1) To make every public space completely silent.
(2) To give residents more choices about where to spend time.
(3) To prevent businesses from using nearby streets.
(4) To replace parks with sound barriers.